



“Enterprises are no longer starting with scale. They’re starting with strategy. New approaches like ‘GCC-in-a-Box’ enable firms to establish focussed, high-skill centres around AI and product engineering”

MONICA PIRGAL
CEO, BHARTIYA CONVERGE



“Smaller GCCs enable faster activation with lower strategic risk. The shift is also driven by the fact that this model is a better size fit for revenue and operating scale”

ARINDAM SEN
PARTNER, EY INDIA

Netsmart and Deepwatch have both set up centres in Bengaluru, with Deepwatch planning to grow its team to over 100 professionals in 18 months, focused on advanced AI development and platform engineering.

Given that these are small, sub-700 people centres, often less than 100 people, collaborating with IT services companies might offer better bang for the buck.

Gupta of Meltwater argues that a captive centre offers an edge that outsourcing cannot match. “Our office is a direct extension of our company’s culture and capabilities. We set the bar on the talent we hire. That control is a big advantage, especially when you want to work on cutting-edge technology,” he says.

Meltwater hires AI and software engineers from institutes like

IIT Hyderabad, BITS, IIIT Hyderabad and IISc Bangalore, among others, and does not partner with IT services providers for its core work.

“GCC is like an office anywhere else,” says ANSR’s Ahuja. “If, for instance, an ecommerce company opens an office in London to hire AI engineers, they will do it themselves. They won’t go to an IT services firm and say, ‘please help me hire people in London.’ If you’re an engineer in that market, why work for a third-party when you can work for the product company itself?”

Beyond talent branding and training on proprietary technologies, Ahuja points to margins—third-party providers typically add 30–50% mark-up on talent costs—as well as control over proprietary data and IP.

NANO CHALLENGES

For all the promise of building niche capabilities, nano-GCCs face a few real constraints.

EY’s Sen says: “Their key challenges would be leadership depth, brand pull and career pathways. Smaller centres must work harder to attract senior talent, build robust governance and offer clearer growth trajectories.”

Chaturvedi of DAMAC adds: “The key challenge is building a cohesive team across multiple locations while maintaining seamless collaboration with our UAE (United Arab Emirates) and international operations.”

Despite the challenges, the trend is expected to rise. As AI reshapes industries and digital skills become scarcer in home markets, the ability to build capability with minimal inertia is becoming a competitive advantage.

For mid-market firms, a 60- or 250-person GCC in India can be the difference between keeping pace with technology shifts and falling behind larger peers.

If the first two decades of India’s GCC growth was written by global giants, the next chapter may well belong to these nano and micro centres. They won’t dominate skylines or campus maps. But in glass towers in Hyderabad, Bengaluru, Pune and Noida, small teams working on AI, product simulations or precision cybersecurity are quietly re-wiring how mid-sized companies operate around the world.

In the coming years, ‘small’ is likely to be very big: compact, focused GCCs delivering high-value capabilities and cost advantages, not from the periphery, but from the core of global operations—anchored in India. **BT**